
Review: CATHOLIC THEOLOGY AND THEOLOGICAL METHOD

Reviewed Work(s): Catholic Theology in the Nineteenth Century: The Quest for a Unitary Method by Gerald A. McCool

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Source: *CrossCurrents*, SUMMER 1978, Vol. 28, No. 2 (SUMMER 1978), pp. 205-207

Published by: University of North Carolina Press

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/24458426>

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these other works. It seems to this reviewer that the real value of this volume lies not so much in any isolated new bits of Rahnerian theology as in his bringing together so much that he has already said on how one can give an intellectually honest justification for being a Christian and a Roman Catholic in the contemporary world. Rahner mentions that the external stimulus toward writing *Foundations* was the statement in Vatican II's Decree on Priestly Formation calling for a course integrating philosophy and theology and focusing on the mystery of Christ. If this volume is seen as a response to this call of Vatican II, what might initially be perceived as a deficiency, namely, the lack of a fully satisfactory philosophical grounding of Rahner's claims about man, his free-

dom and his experience of God, can be explained. For the intended readers would, one could hope, have a solid philosophical grounding so that *Foundations* could presuppose a good deal of philosophy and aim directly at the integration of philosophy and theology. Given the present pluralism even within Catholic philosophy, and in the light of the philosophical background presupposed, the range of readers for whom *Foundations* can fully achieve its goal may be narrowed. However, despite such limitations, Rahner's latest book is certainly a masterly attempt to provide the intelligent Catholic with an intellectually honest justification for his faith.

ROLAND TESKE

CATHOLIC THEOLOGY AND THEOLOGICAL METHOD

Gerald A. McCool, *Catholic Theology in the Nineteenth Century: The Quest for a Unitary Method*. New York: The Seabury Press, 1977. 300 pp. \$14.95.

Contemporary Catholic theology is explicitly conscious of a plurality of methods deriving from a variety of philosophical stances. It is no longer assumed that all Catholic theologians will follow a single method, for example, that of St. Thomas Aquinas. Rather, ecumenical concern and openness characterize most important theologies of today. Gerald McCool's study of last century's Catholic theology reminds us that while such openness has not always been to the fore, there were, even in those sterner days which culminated in official ecclesiastical endorsement of the Thomistic method, intimations of the recent breakthrough.

As the subtitle indicates, the focal

concern for McCool is the quest of a theological method. The question of the nature and possibility of theology was central for nineteenth century theologians. McCool's treatment of the last century's efforts to walk through the intricate and interrelated problems of knowledge, reason, revelation and faith in an effort to balance natural and supernatural components in the theological enterprise is to be welcomed both as a review of a century of theology and an introduction to contemporary discussion of theological method.

McCool rightly considers nineteenth century theology to have been a reaction to the developments of European thought in the eighteenth century. It was the constant preoccupation of last century's theologians to defend the faith in the face of the rationalism of the Enlightenment. "The common aim of Catholic theologians was to show that

the negative conclusions drawn by rationalist philosophers were unwarranted and that belief in positive Christian revelation was intellectually justified." (p. 18) Though not recognized by many at the time, it was necessary for theology to find a method which could acknowledge and adequately balance both natural and supernatural elements. Despite the common aim, it must not be thought that uniformity prevailed.

McCool documents at least three distinct major movements which attempted to meet the same threat. First were the literateurs who intensely distrusted the trends of modern thought and sought refuge in strict traditionalism. They developed a method of restating traditional formulae in a way which would appeal to lettered men of the day. A second group (particularly sensitive to the issues raised in modern thought) never embraced modernity without reserve, but attempted to accommodate much of post-Kantian philosophy. Their method did not always clearly distinguish the natural from the supernatural. The third movement shared the first's distrust of modernity and the second's proclivity to philosophy but insisted on a return directly to pure Aristotelian-Thomist method. As is well known, the neo-Thomist movement finally emerged as most powerful and won the endorsement of ecclesiastical authorities. But that end of nineteenth century developments was not reached without both struggle and luck.

The first reaction, that of the traditionalists, insisted so mightily on the value of supernatural faith and revelation in theology's method that it regarded unaided human reason as utterly incapable of achieving knowledge in moral or religious matters. The French Traditionalists, as McCool terms them, de Bonald, de Lammenais,

de Maistre and Bautain (of whom only Bautain had professional training in philosophy) unanimously suspected the modern trend toward purely natural theology. They turned instead to an insistence on the sole reliability of objective revelation preserved in ecclesiastical tradition.

Bautain, the most moderate of the group, went so far as to regard all knowledge as in some degree dependent on revelation.

Knowledge of God and of the first principles of speculative and moral reasoning depends upon an act of primitive revelation received by the intelligence through 'faith'. Prior to that revelation and its passive reception no mind can think. After its reception, the mind can actively cooperate with God in the development of revelation's virtualities. Thus, drawing on a notion which goes back to Lessing, Bautain, like the Tübingen theologians, argues that God is the great educator of the human race. (p. 51)

Bautain's position was similar to Augustinian illuminism (in the *Confessions* Augustine certainly regards God as his tutor), but it did not sufficiently recognize the power of unaided human intelligence.

A representative member of the second movement, which opposed the traditionalists on the basis of a modified Kantianism, was Georg Hermes. He claimed that all persons, even unaided by supernatural faith or revelation, attained to apodictic certitude with regard to his formulation of the categorical imperative: "Establish and preserve human dignity in yourself and in others." (p. 62) Implied in this certitude was a demand for practical assent to the truth even of others' experience in

order to fulfill moral obligation. Hermes' reliance on this certitude obtainable through the exercise of practical reason and dependence on the experience of others was close in spirit to the positions of the Enlightenment *philosophes*. It found no need to acknowledge the supernatural assistance of grace in coming to theological knowledge.

The third movement, a renaissance of scholasticism, took to task both modernists and traditionalists and opposed taking seriously the issues raised by modern thinkers. Instead, this group returned to scholasticism's balance of natural and supernatural elements in theology's method. The outstanding exponent of the scholastic reaction was Joseph Kleutgen, a German Jesuit who became very influential at Rome. Kleutgen's two major publications extol the virtues of the good old days before theology got thrown off the tracks by post-Cartesian and Kantian thought. His first major volume, *Die Theologie der Vorzeit*, saw publication (as luck would have it) in 1853, "the same year in which the Jesuits on *Civiltà Cattolica* began their campaign for the restoration of Thomism." (p. 168) His second major volume, *Die Philosophie der Vorzeit*, saw Kleutgen equate the issue of the relationship between natural theology and supernatural theology as basically the same as the issue of the relationship between the old (Thomist) theology and the new (post-Cartesian, Kantian) theology. A work on philosophy, of course, saw no need to deal with strict or moderate traditionalism. Kleutgen was transferred to Rome where he was appointed to influential posts and together with his fellow Jesuits on *Civiltà* sparked the interest of ecclesiastical leaders in neo-Thomism.

The cause was aided, curiously, by

the twists in European politics and the tensions between Church and State. McCool points out that as the Papal States were threatened, endangered and, finally, engulfed, theologians were in favor or disfavor as much for their political as for their theological and philosophical ruminations. "The defense of papal power and the defense of Catholic truth were associated in the minds of the early neo-Thomists." (p. 21) So in addition to the intrinsic merits of Thomism's intellectual triumph McCool admits the importance of political position in the endorsement of that movement by Church leaders. Pope Leo XIII issued the endorsement of neo-Thomism in the encyclical *Aeterni Patris* of August 4, 1879. McCool is careful to avoid, however, any simplistic interpretation of Thomism's triumph exclusively in terms of politics and places correct emphasis on the movement's intrinsic merits.

The first two reactions which McCool chronicles emphasized either the supernatural or natural and thus provided a ready context for the more balanced Thomist approach. The twentieth century has seen the continuance of the discussion of theology's method. Leadership continues with such Thomists as Rahner and Lonergan, both of whom, however, have moved to incorporate much of modern wisdom in their methodologies. It should not be thought that McCool treats exclusively of the issue of method. While method provides the focus of his considerations, McCool's book is the first lengthy treatment in English of the general history of Catholic theology in the nineteenth century and so deserves the attention even of readers not interested in method.

WARREN HARRINGTON